

states **BIHAR**

Crime On WHEELS

Even as he flagged off scores of new trains, the security of passengers was perhaps never a priority for Lalu

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

As the railway minister, Lalu Prasad Yadav sanctioned and started scores of new trains on new routes. But each time he flagged off a new train in Bihar—as he did in January when he introduced the Katihar-Jogbani Express—the brass of the Government Railway Police (GRP) anticipated more trouble. Their anxiety was not misplaced. Around 818 trains crisscross daily through Bihar's 3,500-km network of tracks. An acute shortage of manpower in the railway police, however, means more than half of these trains go unescorted while others have only four or five armed police personnel on board.

Take a look at these statistics: the trains passing through Bihar have witnessed 963 incidents of dacoity and looting (439 dacoities and 524 lootings) in the last eight years. This boils down roughly to at least one train robbery every third day. Add to this 506 murders, over 6,000 burglaries, more than 850 cases of drugging and overall 20,000 cognisable offences committed on running trains during this period. The conclusion: more than seven crimes take place everyday on trains passing through Bihar.

According to the National Crime Records Bureau, Bihar—where 2,076 IPC crimes were recorded—alone accounted for almost 11 per cent of crimes reported by the railway police in 2007 across the country. In 2008, although the number of dacoity and looting came down, the murder toll

went up to 58 from 39. Worse still, even Naxalites are carrying out attacks against railway police to loot arms and ammunition. During the last five years, they have looted 80 firearms and 2,777 live cartridges and killed 10 policemen.

Under these circumstances, passenger safety remains a major challenge, say police officers, conceding that while new trains are introduced in every railway budget, precious little has been done to ensure proper



MANY GRP PERSONNEL ARE FORCED INTO MAKESHIFT LIVING ARRANGEMENTS IN ABANDONED TRAIN COACHES

security of the passengers. "We now have longer trains which require more than one escort team. The Railways cannot provide security cover to each train or set up new GRP stations whenever a new railway

station is established or an existing one is upgraded," says a GRP official.

When trains are running on time, GRP can provide only four constables and a havildar per train. "But with trains running late, day trains ply at